

HORIZON-WIDERA-2022-ERA-01-60: A European competence centre for science communication

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 3.00 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 3.00 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following expected outcomes:

- Consolidation of knowledge and development of guidelines, tools, innovative strategies, and recommendations to improve science communication for all research and innovation actors;
- Establishment of a European competence centre for science communication, sustained beyond the lifetime of funding;
- Increased networking and mutual learning, higher quality, more trustworthy, and more rapidly mobilised science communication by national authorities, businesses, civil society organisations, other stakeholders and projects.

Scope: Science communication is a scientific discipline, an activity conducted by career scientists and science outreach organisations, and a specific career pathway followed by journalists. It has the potential to improve science-society relations by increasing the transparency of science, building trust in the processes and outcomes of science, and raising scientific literacy. It can also improve the uptake of science by society and support evidence-based policy making.

Science and science communication have been undergoing radical changes over recent years, creating opportunities that may, in turn, pose new challenges. For instance, traditional media are increasingly being superseded by social media with more user-edited content; rapid diffusion of open access or pre-peer review papers gives the general public access to research that was previously locked behind paywalls; and open data enable a wider set of actors to interact with, analyse and interpret research results than in the past.

The covid-19 pandemic has highlighted the importance of communicating scientific knowledge and recommendations to respond to a fast-moving and critical threat. It is important to learn from this and other experiences when science communication has been essential to conveying scientific knowledge and recommendations on critical issues, to explaining how hypotheses, experiments and uncertainties are also part of the scientific method, to build capacities and strengthen networks, and to ensure greater ability in the future to react rapidly and effectively to critical situations.

This action has two parts, both of which must be addressed:

The first part consists of consolidating the evidence base on science communication from on-going and past projects and initiatives⁹³, covering a wide range of existing and potential critical areas for research and innovation for society. Particular attention should be paid to contextual issues (geography, gender, age, socio-economic status, etc.) that affect the uptake or effectiveness of science communication. Policy reports and recommendations, guidelines, and innovative strategies should be developed for all research and innovation actor types; potential targets should include government agencies and public authorities, research funding and performing organisations, and civil society organisations. An important outcome should

⁹³ In particular, but not limited to, projects supported by Horizon 2020's SwafS-19-2018-2019-2020 topic, but other relevant projects and initiatives within and outside the Framework Programmes should also be considered.